

Before marriage, your conversations and negotiations, if conducted well, will have yielded crucial information about who keeps money safer. If your potential partner is bad with money, is carrying more debt than you, and spends too much, reconsider the merger. I wouldn't buy a company with that kind of financial profile.

But if you still want to proceed down the aisle, you can prevent disaster. You can still protect your money. Keep your Secret 10 yours and yours alone. Keep your own savings and investment accounts. Open a joint checking account in which you're each responsible to deposit a certain amount from your paychecks. Use that account to pay bills. Be separately responsible for your own debts, and jointly responsible for any debts incurred in the marriage. You're doing this to preempt disaster.

I'll add this bit of atypical advice: If my potential partner carried a lot of debt, I'd delay the wedding until the debt was gone, or consider marrying someone else. But if you're in a position to pay off your partner's debts, and you want to, don't make it a loan, make it a gift. This cuts down on resentment and introduces generosity into the relationship. It also reinforces the fact that this is a merger in every sense of the word. That said, if your partner responds to that gift by incurring more debt, double-check the prenup, rethink your plans, and call your lawyer.

Money Mistake: Damn the Risks, You're Getting Hitched

THE FIX: INVEST IN YOUR FUTURE, NOT IN YOUR WEDDING

Sometimes, when couples contemplating marriage take a cold hard look at their financial situation, they realize the potential financial drain a failed marriage can be, so they opt out. I encourage this, especially if you're not going to have kids. Let me repeat: *If you're not going to have kids, don't get married.* Live together, yes, commit for life, sure! Sign a cohabitation agreement, absolutely. But get married? No. I say this as a happily married man, so I'm not telling you to forgo the intimacy, security, and commitment that come from an